

When a Machine Learning Tool Locks an Oral Epic into a Digital Script, Do You Preserve the Culture or Kill Its Natural Ability to Evolve?

Background Information

Oral Epics as a Living Tradition

Vietnam is home to fifty-four different ethnic groups, and many of these communities sustain their language and history by passing down oral epics, which are stories that tell the tales of ancient heroes and historical events. Traditionally, these tales are passed down entirely through performances and storytelling during community rituals. Over centuries now, oral epics have become a living tradition that relies mostly on the physical presence of a speaker and the village listening.

However, many of these traditions are disappearing at a significant rate due to rapid industrialization, which is the process of building factories and modern cities that drives urban migration. More specifically, many more young adults are now moving to large metropolitan centers for better jobs and educational opportunities. For example, according to the General Statistics Office of Vietnam, about 61.8 percent of all migrants to city centers in Vietnam range from 20 to 39 years of age (General Statistics Office 24). Additionally, 200 migrants for every 1,000 people are living in metropolitan areas like Hanoi and Ho Chi Minh City (General Statistics Office 28). Because of this movement, significantly fewer young people are learning the native languages of their ancestors. Surveys from local cultural institutes show that in several indigenous groups, less than a quarter of the youth can speak their native language fluently.

The Digitizing Vietnam project is a major initiative run by the Vietnam Studies Center at Fulbright University Vietnam and Columbia University, using funds from the Henry Luce Foundation ("Digitizing Vietnam"). This project aims to incorporate computer models to transcribe and store indigenous cultural records online ("Digitizing Vietnam"). In addition to institutional digital humanities projects, computational linguists in Vietnam are building speech-synthesis and natural language processing frameworks for low-resource indigenous languages. For instance, researchers have developed cross-lingual speech synthesis models to generate spoken Mường dialects directly from text (Đồng Phạm 139). Furthermore, recent computational initiatives have compiled multilingual corpora for minority languages like Cham, Khmer, and Tày-Nùng to safeguard their linguistic heritage and prevent data scarcity (Dinh et al. 1).

The Philosophical Question

While major research institutions are attempting to effectively safeguard the historical contents of oral epics, these efforts also introduce an important philosophical discussion. In particular, when someone converts an

oral performance into text files, we have to ask ourselves a question: "Are we protecting the culture or are we turning neighborhood tradition customs into words in computer data?"

Walter Ong's Argument

Why Oral Composition Is Dynamic

One compelling argument for this topic is rooted in the philosophy of Walter Ong, a philosopher and scholar. In his book, *Orality and Literacy*, Ong argues that writing restructures how we think, and that something specific to oral composition is lost when a performance is fixed on the page (Ong). To be more specific, during an oral performance, words are usually more dynamic, meaning that they are constantly changing, such as adjusting tones or minor details during the performance. The reason behind this is that storytellers do not record their lines in books but rather have a brief idea of what they will perform, meaning that they usually alter some details based on the reactions of listeners.

Ong states that when a person copies an oral performance down on paper, they are unintentionally ruining its essence (Ong). To be more precise, when an algorithm listens to an older singer and produces a transcript, that transcript tends to become the official version of the myth. Once a version is official, the epic stops changing, which also removes the flexibility aspect of oral stories. This is a major problem because traditions are not valuable because of words; instead, the value lies in a person's ability to make them. More specifically, before transcripts existed, an epic survived only if each generation had someone to perform it live, so the community had a strong reason to train one. However, with a written version of an oral epic, there is no longer motivation for a community to learn oral epics, but rather to read the recorded version on a screen. Consequently, later generations can recite the epic without anyone learning to perform it, and the skill can disappear in the near future.

Overall, Ong's argument warns us that a transcript records one performance accurately and then presents it as the epic itself. In other words, we would save the outer shell of rituals, the oral lines, and ignore the interaction and adaptation that makes an oral performance unique in the first place.

Jean-François Lyotard's Philosophy

Knowledge That Must Become Data

Another impactful argument comes from the perspective of Jean-François Lyotard, a philosopher who investigated how the rise of computers and digital technology changes the way society handles knowledge. Lyotard argued that in today's world, knowledge must be translated into data in order to be processed by software (Lyotard). However, Lyotard points out that the current framework creates a filtering system where if a piece of knowledge or cultural expression cannot be turned into data lines, then society would eventually forget about it completely (Lyotard).

What the Filter Leaves Out

When we apply Jean-François Lyotard's idea to the transcription of minority oral epics, it proves to be a dangerous system. To clarify, an oral story is a lot more than just a line of scripts; it also depends significantly on the tone, pace, spirit of the performer, and the atmosphere of the performance. Factors such as when the performer paused, changes in tone, speed, and attitude are factors that can only be felt or seen during a live performance. Consequently, a voice-to-text system built by large organizations can capture the sounds and language of oral epics but cannot record the spiritual depth or the performer's emotional feelings into its database. As a result, these factors that an algorithm is incapable of recording would be filtered out of the system and eventually be forgotten about. Lyotard's philosophy shows us that by relying on artificial intelligence to translate oral epics, we are filtering out what makes an oral story unique and special in the first place. Essentially, with the introduction of voice-to-text AI technology, we are shrinking our cultural history rather than preserving it.

Counterpoint: Kwame Anthony Appiah and Cultural Change

Cultures as Dynamic Systems

However, not every thinker views the translation of oral epics as disadvantageous. Kwame Anthony Appiah, a modern philosopher who studies cultural ethics and globalization, argues that cultures are dynamic systems that must adapt if they want to continue thriving for a longer amount of time (Appiah). More specifically, he argues that when a minority group encounters a predicament, such as rapid modernization and language loss, using new tools to preserve their knowledge and history should be seen as reasonable.

Consequently, if we apply Appiah's ideas to the current situation in Vietnam, refusing to transcribe oral stories at all would lead to the cultural erasure of most minority groups. The major problem currently is how the majority of young people are moving to major manufacturing hubs and urban centers, which leaves older oral epic performers with no successor to pass the tradition down to. Because of this, if tech groups like VinBigData or the Digitizing Vietnam project do not record these elders, then the oral epics will vanish entirely when the current generation passes away.

Who Gets to Decide

Additionally, Appiah pushes this further through his criticism of cultural preservationism, the assumption that outsiders are entitled to define what an authentic version of a culture looks like. In *Cosmopolitanism*, he stated that such thinking leads to telling a community it cannot have the technologies and conveniences that everyone else takes for granted (Appiah). When applying this concept to the current situation in Vietnam, demanding that minority groups remain unrecorded in order to protect their orality is a judgment made on behalf of a community that may want the recordings, and may have requested them. Whether the elders themselves see a transcript as a violation or as insurance is a factual question and it belongs to them to answer.

Holding the Views Together

Two Ways of Weighing the Trade

When observing this topic from a wider scope, there is a clear dilemma between keeping the live feeling of a custom and using technology to make sure it doesn't get forgotten. On one hand, the arguments from Ong and Lyotard show us that letting a computer program transcribe oral poetry can flatten the tradition and stop it from changing naturally (Ong; Lyotard). They remind us that an app cannot capture the shared energy of a village gathering or the physical presence of a storyteller. On the other hand, Appiah's perspective emphasizes that AI transcription technology provides a lifeline for minority groups that are losing their language due to modern migration (Appiah). He also adds that it should be up to the minority group themselves to decide.

Ultimately, whether the implementation of AI speech-to-text translation is beneficial depends on a person's definition of cultural preservation. More specifically, if we treat the text file as a replacement for the live performance, then the values of these oral epics would be erased. On the contrary, if it is used as a tool to reconnect people with their roots when they are far away, then the technology could potentially help a person keep their heritage alive.

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